

excelled in quality tests. The Zebronics ZEB-4000W was also very close to it.

The ZEB-4000W, due to its lack of high-frequency range performance, didn't do too well in the bells test, and all the rings sounded rather flat—finer harmonics couldn't be distinguished.

Fooobar Frequency Test

Fooobar's ability to generate steady frequencies or even frequency sweeps is very useful in finding out how well speakers can handle different frequencies. It's a good test to find small weaknesses in the best of speakers. There were quite a few surprising outcomes.

Although the Altec Lansing MX5021 ploughed through all the frequencies effortlessly, there were some sounds around the 50 Hz frequency range that created some vibrations in the woofer.

A big noticeable problem with many speakers is the how sharp the tone would become when the volume level was pushed beyond the 50-60 per cent mark. This is mostly because of the satellites trying to play the frequencies meant for the woofer, or the other way around. The Zebronics ZEB-SW8000 had an odd problem



Altec Lansing MX5021

where the woofer would give very little output, and an occasional kicking sound at higher volumes on extremely low frequencies.

Music Test

The strongest point of 2.1 speakers is music, and the real fun part of the test was listening to our favourite tracks at mind-blowing volume levels.

The top place again went to the MX5021. The woofer per-

formed exceptionally, with tight, hard bass and booming sound where expected. The woofer on the Logitech Z-2300 also had a respectable amount of bass. The bass on the Z-2300 was not as hard as the MX5021 at all.

The Zebronics ZEB-4000W had a very nice bass too. The high frequencies weren't exaggerated, but the higher mids were a little too pronounced. The comparatively less treble meant a slight lack of sparkling or crispness in the sound.

Both the Artis S111-FM and S111-R are exactly the same in terms of quality. The woofer, although light, is pretty powerful and displaces a lot of air—we could feel it more than a foot away. Unfortunately, it lacks a deep bass because of its light-weight woofer design, which didn't make listening to music a great experience—especially in the bass-heavy genres like rock and metal.

The Altec Lansing BXR1121 is pretty good at music. It went through all the tests with some more than decent results for its clean, natural tone. The only drawback is that these are fairly low-powered speakers, so the woofer doesn't pump out the bass you'd like. Still, for a small room, these will do well. A low-powered speaker set has its own advantages—you can push the speaker to its limits and your sound still won't distort.

Having heard some really great quality from some of the other 2.1 speakers of Altec Lansing, the FX4021 is a disappointment. The woofer is decent, but the satellites are pretty appalling, with major distortion even at mid-level volumes. The Altec Lansing VS2421 had a very warm sound signature which makes it ideal for jazz music.

TECH-COM has generally suffered from really coloured sound—the speakers are mostly high on treble, which makes the sound very unnatural. A lot of equaliser tweaks are required to cut down on the lower-highs before you can get the right tone out of these speakers.

Movie playback is also very good with the 2.1 speakers, even if you do miss out on the sur-

round sound experience. The MX5021's solid bass works wonders. Following it were the closely performing Logitech Z-2300, Altec Lansing BXR1121, Zebronics ZEB-SW8000, and Logitech X-240. These are speakers with not-so-hard bass.

And The Winner Is...!

The best speaker for music from all the tests that we ran is the Altec Lansing MX5021—its sheer power and undistorted sound, natural tone, with the right amount of crispness makes it an excellent performer. It's not very costly either, at an MRP of Rs 7,500. In some markets, it's available for around Rs 6,500, which makes it a steal.

A little far behind is the Logitech Z-2300. The woofer isn't as tight as the MX5021, or as powerful, but it stands its ground when you demand power of it. It does well for music, and the slightly boomy woofer does its part for movies too.

The Zebronics ZEB-4000W grabs a surprising third place. Although a little off in tone, the sound still had vibrance and clarity, which makes it a very good speaker set. A bit of tweaking with your media player's equaliser, and you can get decent music from this speaker set for sure. It's got good, heavy bass, but it needs you to turn up the bass a fair bit before you get the setting just right.

The Altec Lansing BXR1121 makes a for very good value-for-money product at just Rs 1,250. Although it lacks power, this is actually an excellent buy for people who want a fairly mid-powered sound system for their PC.

The Artis S111R is yet another product that makes a lot of sense for the budget-minded. Although a little costlier than the BXR1121 at Rs 1,500, it isn't a lot more expensive either, and has a slightly better subwoofer.

The Logitech speakers are really good, too but their biggest fault is the pricing. The Z-2300, for example, is fairly good—not better than the Altec Lansing MX5021—but it still priced at Rs 3,000 more! If you're looking for the ultimate 2.1 speakers, then blindly opt for the Altec

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Altec Lansing BXR1121

Lansing MX5021. It is a very good bargain.

SURROUND SOUND SPEAKERS

Surround sound speakers are meant to serve a completely different purpose—watching movies with, well, surround sound. The sensation of being in the middle of the action is something that you can experience in a good movie theatre. The speakers we've tested should be able to give more or less the same experience, but in the comfort of your sofa with your family and friends. The freedom to pause the movie and grab your unlimited supply of popcorn and your cola whenever you want is just one of the perks of having your own little home theatre system. Although the emphasis would have to be on the surround movie tests, we still must focus on the best audio quality overall. After all, you won't just be using your system for movies. While we received mostly 5.1 speak-

Kharma Grand Exquisite

The Kharma Grand Exquisite is a \$2,20,000 speaker which like its price uses exotic components too. Diamond tweeters are used for the high frequencies and Kevlar for the bass. Wiring is done using pure gold and silver. Each speaker weighs 440 Kg and they have an explosive power of 500W. If that doesn't impress you, then the majestic looks surely will.



ers, there were also a couple of 4.1 speakers—Creative Inspire M4500, TECH-COM SSD-2800 and the TECH-COM SSD-3400.

First Glimpse—Build Quality, Design... And Some Issues

The Logitech Z-5500 is the scariest of all the speakers that we received—the woofer is massive! The satellites were of 61 W RMS each. Most complete speaker sets—including the woofer and satellites—weren't made this powerful. There were sufficiently long cables provided with the speakers, although prospective buyers should think of ways to tuck the cables away—they can get your room a little messy.

The Altec Lansing VS3251 is a cute little 5.1 setup. Although not as monstrous as the other speakers we saw, it is built rather well, is compact and comes with a chunky remote with very good buttons. The Philips MMS460 has a very light woofer and we had our doubts about its performance in the bass tests. The satellites were really built well and heavy. This is one of the most

Stand Back MP3, Enter Vinyls?

MP3s have come to be known as the best audio quality to most of the people using them—a wrong notion. Audio CDs easily surpass MP3s at the best possible bitrate and quality, but true audiophiles don't quite agree even there. There are many who would say that vinyls hold the crown for quality. Vinyls—for those who aren't aware—are better known as gramophone records. Unlike CDs, data on vinyls was stored as analogue. There is a groove that runs from the outside to the inside of the vinyl disc, and this groove contains the information which is read by a delicate nib—like on an ink pen. Data stored on either side of the groove is used to play stereo sound. This is far different from how CDs or DVDs are read.

Vinyls are said to be able to store a larger frequency range than CDs. There's



also a unique tone to the music which many consider comes from the inaccuracies of a relatively crude technology. It sounds very natural and very warm, unlike digital formats which have a very precise razor-like crispness to them.

Before you start unpacking your parents' old record player, we should just remind you that there was a reason why vinyls got out of the market in the first place—they're bulky, and very delicate. The surface is susceptible to scratches, and any kind of damage would completely ruin it. Now with CDs and the protective layer, there are no such worries. They were also very huge and therefore not portable—imagine going to work today in a train with a bunch of 12-inch records in your hand and even bulkier record player!

Perfect8—The Force

Each of these transparent monster's stands weighs around 200 Kg. The frequency range extends all the way from 8 Hz to 50 KHz. All the drivers are housed in a glass casing. The high frequency range is not driven by some tweeter but through a 1.6 m long ribbon using a neodymium magnet system. The price for The Force with 2 towers and 4 outbound woofers is said to be around \$295,000.

